BEFORE YOU START

Workbook 4: How to use it

This is one of four workbooks that cover the middle of the course.

Your gifts How you've been designed - your strengths, according to you and others.

The space of your life Mapping your story, and what has happened in each season of it.

Expressing your calling Narrowing it to a sentence, then opening it back up.

Your growth plan Turning all of it into something you will actually do. **This workbook**

THREE THINGS WORTH REMEMBERING

This is not a test. Nobody marks it and nobody else reads it unless you choose to show them. An honest half-answer is worth more than a tidy one.

It is meant to be unhurried. Three or four sittings of half an hour is better than one long evening. The thinking needs time to settle.

You are not meant to do it alone. There are conversations with your coach built into each booklet. They matter more than any single page in it.

WHAT YOUR COACH IS FOR

A coach is not a mentor handing down their own experience. Their job is to ask questions and let you find your own answers. If they start telling you what they would do, it is entirely fair to point that out.

You will need a pen, a Bible, and somewhere you're unlikely to be interrupted. Your 'gifts and talents' results may not be fully complete, as it can take a while to get others to provide their assessments of you - don't let that stop you making progress on this workbook.

HOW TO GET THE MOST FROM THE BIBLE READINGS

These devotional materials are designed to provide the New Testament backdrop to your ongoing consideration of what Christian work and calling is.

Read them slowly. Read them multiple times. Pray through them. Underline bits, meditate on them. Memorise them, and write down what you sense the Holy Spirit might be saying to you as you do all of the above. The Bible passages, by definition, are God speaking. Embrace His words, listen as attentively as you can. To keep this sustainable, we'd recommend you swap it out for your quiet times, rather than treating it as additional material.

READING 1 OF 4

1 Thessalonians 4:9-12

A quiet life, and your own hands

Using your talents for the glory of God doesn't have to be *flashy*. 'Working with your hands' would have been looked down on and disrespected by the gentile peoples of the time. Paul's desire for the Thessalonians - living quietly, minding their own business, walking properly before outsiders, not depending on others - aren't glamorous. **Jesus can use us to do incredible things, but our ambition should be deeply rooted in simple daily witness and humility.**

> *"Lord, help me to do great things as though they were little, since I do them with your power, and little things as though they were great, since I do them in your name!"*
>
> — Blaise Pascal

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

— Living quietly, minding your own business, walking properly before outsiders, not depending on others - how are these going for you? Think about each in turn, and consider what they do, or should, look like in your life and context.

— There's a simplicity about the working life that Paul is sketching out for the Thessalonians here. Make a list of all the different aspects of your 'work' - paid or unpaid - at the moment. Are there any simplifications you could make, to place more focus on the things God may be calling you to?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

— Worship - thanking God that, although He is utterly infinite, his claims can be lived out in very simple ways. He isn't making us jump through hoops, or restricting access to His presence to just the clever or wealthy few

— Confessing and repenting of times where you have not been 'living quietly, minding your own business, walking properly before outsiders'

— Asking to be 'taught by God to love' others more deeply and sacrificially

SECTION FOUR

Your growth plan

All of this is worth very little if nothing changes in practice. This section turns what you have discovered into specific actions, and then places them across the next eighteen months. The aim is to create a plan on one page rather than a feeling that fades.

Read these first

Luke 14:25–33	Counting the cost before you begin.
1 Timothy 4, especially v14–15	Do not neglect your gift. Give yourself wholly to it.
Philippians 3:7–16	Not arrived, but pressing on.
Colossians 3:23–24	Whatever you do, and who you are ultimately working for.

> A plan made in a moment of clarity rarely survives contact with an ordinary week. That is not a reason to skip it - it is a reason to make it smaller than you want to.

SECTION FOUR · STEP ONE

What needs to be in the plan

A good growth plan has five ingredients. Write specific, doable actions under each — one line per action. Two or three in each is plenty.

Taking steps

We learn by doing. Experiments clarify a calling faster than more thinking, so these usually come early.

What are you unsure about, and what could you actually try in order to find out?

Grow your gifting

Skills compound slowly. Start early and expect the payoff later in the plan.

How will you deepen what you already have, and add what you do not?

Character

The foundation everything else rests on. Begin now, and let it run throughout.

Which spiritual disciplines will you deepen in?

SECTION FOUR · STEP ONE

The last two

Mentorship

Mentors save you years. Ask early, so the relationship has time to bear fruit.

Who will you ask, and in what areas? Whose story do you want to hear?

Disciple others

Teaching others what you've learned cements your own growth.

Who could you help grow in something connected to your calling?

IF YOU ARE STUCK

Volunteer somewhere that tests this · shadow someone doing it for a day · take a course in a core skill · find a stretch project at work · establish a weekly rhythm of silence · join a small group for accountability · ask someone to meet monthly · interview three people about their calling · help one person a few steps behind you · teach a session on what you have learned.

Check before moving on. Is any of the five empty? A rounded plan usually touches all of them. If character and mentorship are blank, the rest tends not to last.

READING 2 OF 4

Colossians 3:22-24; Ephesians 6:5-8

Working for the Lord, not for men

These passages reframe how we think about earthly masters - 'working for the Lord rather than for people', 'the Master you are serving is Christ.' Our attitude should be wholehearted, sincere, and full of good will, with an eye not on our earthly paycheck but our eternal reward. In almost any work situation, however secular it feels, you can embed your faith into it by adopting this mindset. Christians are disciples, **apprentices of Jesus**. Through work experiences, we become more like Him; growing in gratitude, compassion, humility, perseverance, and generosity. So **whatever you do, Jesus is your boss.** Whether you feel called to the work or not, it should be done as if He is your line manager.

> *"When we work for Christ out of obligation, it feels like work. But when we truly love Christ, our work is a manifestation of that love, and it feels like love."*
>
> — Francis Chan

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

— How have 'work' experiences (perhaps including education) shaped you as a disciple of Jesus so far?

— In practice, who are your 'masters' at the moment? How does submitting to serving and obeying them feel at the moment?

— In what tangible ways does seeing Jesus as your primary boss change your daily life?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

— Worship Jesus! Thank Him for being interested in what goes on in your daily 'work' life. Thank Him that we will 'receive an inheritance as our reward' regardless of what our earthly paychecks look like

— Confessing where you've been rendering 'eye-service, as a people-pleaser' to your boss, doing whatever gets you an easy life rather than 'working heartily'

— Asking for the Holy Spirit to make His fruit (Galatians 5) more manifest in your life, particularly your interactions with your boss. Ask Him to make you more like Jesus, through - and for - your 'work' context

SECTION FOUR · STEP TWO

When will you do it?

Now place each action into one of the next six quarters (18 months). Aim for fewer things done well, a plan you can actually keep rather than one that looks impressive.

QUARTER	PLANNED ACTIONS
1 Months 1 - 3	
2 Months 4 - 6	
3 Months 7 - 9	
4 Months 10 - 12	
5 Months 13 - 15	

6 Months 16 - 18	

READING 3 OF 4

Matthew 5:13-16; Philippians 2:13--16

Salt, light, and the people you work with

Christians can stand out at work as missionaries. It's often the context we spend the most time with people who don't follow Jesus. **Whatever our specific callings, we are all called to be salt and light in the world, bringing Jesus to those who don't know Him.** A missional lifestyle ('good works') is needed for our evangelism to be credible. Christians being 'salt and light' goes beyond merely engaging individuals with the gospel, vital though that is. This kind of 'cultural renewal' might be as narrow as helping make your workplace a context where people thrive, or as wide as serving society as a whole, especially the marginalised.

> *"The rapid growth of the Christianity in its first couple of centuries must often have been not from formal preaching, but informal chattering to friends and chance acquaintances, in homes and wine shops, on walks, and around market stalls. They went everywhere gossiping the gospel; they did it naturally, enthusiastically, and with the conviction of those who are not paid to say that sort of thing.... Until once again the task of evangelism is something which is seen as incumbent on every baptised Christian, and is backed up by a quality of living which outshines the best that unbelief can muster, we are unlikely to make much headway through techniques of evangelism."*
>
> — Michael Green

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

— What parts of your life might make the gospel attractive to people you 'work' with?

— What does being 'salt and light' look like in your 'work' context? Are there specific people you are serving and caring for - not because they're some kind of conversion project - but out of genuine love? Have you shared your faith with some of them?

— Asking people questions to make them think about faith is often an effective way to begin to share some aspects of the gospel with them. What questions could you ask?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

— Worship Jesus! Thank Him we don't 'labour in vain', and that He is 'working in us'

— Confessing where you've 'grumbled and disputed' or not been 'blameless and innocent' at work

— Asking the Holy Spirit for opportunities to share your faith with those you work with

SECTION FOUR · STEP THREE

The first step

A plan without a date is a wish. But plans change, and that's ok. Fill this 'first step plan' in before you close the booklet, so you know you're clear on where to start.

The very first thing I will do

I will do it by

The person I will get to ask me whether I did it or not

FOR THE COACH · CONVERSATION FOUR · ABOUT 45 MINUTES

What this conversation is for

Making the plan realistic, and agreeing how they will be held to it.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

"Which of these will actually happen, and which is wishful thinking?"
"What is the first thing, and when precisely will you do it?"
"What is most likely to derail this in the next six months?"
"Who else needs to know about this plan for it to survive?"

WHAT TO LOOK OUT FOR

Over-loaded quarters are the commonest failure. Two or three real commitments beat ten aspirations. Plans with no character or mentorship work in them tend not to last.

AVOID Ending without a specific date for the first step, and a date to review it together.

READING 4 OF 4

Revelation 21:1-2, 22:1-2; 1 Corinthians 15:58

Nothing done in the Lord is wasted

Adam and Eve were placed in Eden to release the undeveloped potential God had deposited in the Garden. They were to **fill the planet not just with humans, but with cultural flourishing**.

We can work this out from the end of the story. Ezekiel and Revelation end with descriptions of how God will remake a perfect world, at the end of history. The relationship between God and humans is restored; evil and its effects are destroyed. But in this re-created, perfect world, God and his people aren't back in a Garden of Eden. They live - and work - in a Garden *City*, a place of cultural flourishing. While teaching about the resurrection and the End Times, Paul tells the Corinthians that, in the Lord, 'our labour is not in vain'. **What we do now, however frustrated and imperfect, if it's done for Jesus, will be made worth it, it will be made new. Our work now points toward the Garden City.**

> *"Everyone will be forgotten, nothing we do will make any difference, and all good endeavours, even the best, will come to naught. Unless there is God. If the God of the Bible exists, and there is a True Reality beneath and behind this one, and this life is not the only life, then every good endeavour, even the simplest ones, pursued in response to God's calling, can matter forever."*
>
> — Timothy Keller, Every Good Endeavour

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

— Think about what you're working on today - what bits of it might make it to the 'Garden City'? What might it look like when it's 'made new'?

— Given that from an eternal perspective no labour - in the Lord - is in vain, what would you attempt in this life, even if you knew you would 'fail'?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

— Worship Jesus! Thank Him that He is coming back, that He will make all things new, that he will wipe away every tear, and 'make every evil thing untrue'

— Confessing the areas of your life where you're living without an 'eternal perspective'

— Asking for the Holy Spirit to give you a vision for how you could contribute to 'cultural renewal', and the power to work toward that

FINISHING

Two things left, both online

You have done the paper part. There are two things left, and they are online for a reason.

ONE

The same five questions you answered at the start

You will not be shown your earlier answers until afterwards. That is deliberate, knowing would change what you put. Seeing the points together allows people realise how far they have come.

TWO

A letter to yourself, in a year's time

Write to the person who will be reading this in twelve months. Tell them what you have worked out, what you are afraid will happen, and what you want them to hold you to. Ask them a direct question.

It is sealed until then, and nobody else ever reads it.

BEFORE YOU PUT THIS DOWN

Date I finished the workbook

Date I went back online to finish

For we are his workmanship,

created in Christ Jesus

for good works,

which God prepared beforehand,

that we should walk in them.

Ephesians 2:10